

“As a minister, I should not be expected to be hands-on at the scene of the tragedy.”

**PRATIM CHATTERJEE, MINISTER
FOR FIRE AND EMERGENCY SERVICES**



of the ruling Left Front, the Writers' Building, is also a victim of the apathy of the Government and it is sheer luck that till now a tragedy has not occurred. Chatterjee has yet to implement the recommendations of a committee headed by Principal Secretary (Fire) P.S. Kathiresan, which was submitted to him in August 2008. The report pointed out that even Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee was at risk as his chamber is located right under the police directorate which contains huge amounts of inflammable objects.

Mehta Building, Kolkata's wholesale pharmaceutical business hub, had seen a major fire in 2008. But nothing has changed really with the building, cramped with small offices. Burrabazar, centre for Kolkata's wholesale trade, is overrun by

**FIREFIGHTERS BATTLED FOR
EIGHT HOURS WHEN A FIRE BROKE
OUT IN THE SEVEN-STORY BLOCK**

Market, saw a major fire break out in 1985, at the height of the Christmas season. But even decades later, very little has been done to ensure that what is left of the original building do not again suffer the same fate as the parts that were burnt down. In 2008, 12 people died in a fire at a garments store in the northern fringes of the city.

The West Bengal Government has now formed an 11-member probe panel to look into all aspects of the tragedy at Stephen Court. The committee will be headed by former home secretary Sourin Roy. "It will examine the legal condition of the building and the nature of modifications that was carried out in later years," says Chief Secretary Ashok Mohan Chakraborty.

The Stephen Court tragedy brought into the limelight two aspects that many Kolkatans know instinctively: that the fire service is inadequate in its resources and the fact that modifications and alterations to buildings have been done over the years flouting norms. But what raised the hackles of many citizens was the attitude of Fire Minister Chatterjee. Only a few weeks back he was literally breathing fire over construction of galleries at Eden Gardens and questioning the safety aspect of high-profile spectators sitting in such structures during IPL matches, but when Stephen Court happened, he refused to take moral responsibility. He even went on to say that he was "learning" from the experience and as a minister he should not be expected to be hands-on at the ground of the tragedy. "There's no point in blaming the fire brigade. I believe fire prevention is more important than fire-fighting. Prevention saves a lot of precious life and property," he says. That is all very true, but surely the authorities have not cracked the whip on those who violated and blatantly flouted the fire norms. ■

■ This is one of the first buildings inspected by the newly formed team that has been entrusted to look into the safety angles in old buildings. The team said faults were detected in the fire-fighting arrangements and the wiring.

METROPOLITAN BUILDING



■ The building did see a facelift around 4 years ago and is home to a number of private and government offices. The ancient wooden staircases and lack of security at the entrance add to the hazards with most fire-safety norms being flouted.

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through which a fire engine will have difficulty in entering. In the residential buildings like the Queen's and Karnani Mansion, many homes have been converted into offices and no norms have been followed.

There are more than 15,000 buildings in the city that lack proper maintenance. The administrative hub

buildings that are old, susceptible to fire, and are cramped together with narrow lanes and bylanes making it impossible for even cars to manoeuvre, leave aside fire engines. Kolkata's daily markets, like Gariahat and Maniktala all are potential fire hazards. Kolkata's pride Hogg Market, popularly known as New